

Shada — Outfit Build Guide

Infiltration dress — one costume, and the scale armour is the whole design.

THIS FILE IS DERIVED FROM `outfits.yaml`. That file's components: list is the source of truth — route, quantity, status and the reasoning for every piece. When it changes, this changes. Do not edit this file to record a design decision; edit `outfits.yaml` and rewrite this from it.

Start here — the two things that decide this build

~440 plates. That is the hidden cost of the costume and it dwarfs everything else on this list. Read the plate section before you order anything.

Pattern the flank panels first. They are half the plate count, and their area depends on a pattern nobody has cut yet. Everything else can wait behind them.

The armour is five pieces, and only five

Piece	Where	Route
Gauntlet	her right forearm	printed shell
Scale cap	her left shoulder	made, ~90 plates
Scale patch	her left outer thigh	made, ~130 plates
Flank panels ×2	laced across the centre front, over the ribs	made, ~110 each

NO BREASTPLATE. Her chest and sternum stay plain cloth between the panels. The armour appears in those five places and nowhere else.

The cap, the patch and the panels all move like heavy cloth. **The gauntlet is the one exception** — a solid shell that does not flex at all.

The plates

Printed ×440. 10 to 15 mm across. Regular equilateral hexagons, one printed master repeated — identical in size and outline across the whole costume.

Re-confirmed 2026-08-01 against a generation that came back three to four times too coarse. **If you can count the plates at a glance, they are wrong.** A patch should read as a dense field of many tiny pieces, not a few large ones.

Because they print identical, all the mismatch is painted on. Cut from salvaged hull plate, so mismatched alloys oxidising at different rates: dull grey steel, blackened iron, dark bronze, pale worn pewter, rust-red oxidised iron.

NO BRASS AND NO VERDIGRIS. Within any one patch the metal is broadly consistent, with only two or three plates obviously replaced later.

Each plate carries a **raised** serpent ridge — soft, worn, rounded, never engraved and never a recessed stamp.

Three or four dies repeating across a panel, never a unique curl on every plate: it is a manufacturer's mark cast into cheap hull plate at the mill, industrial and meaningless. What differs between neighbours is the *wear*, never the mark.

Laid edge to edge, almost touching, a thin dark seam of backing between them. **Tessellated flat in one plane — never overlapped, never shingled.** It must never read as carbon fibre or machined hex panelling.

Plates are missing on purpose

Five to ten absent from each flank panel, three to five from the cap, leaving the hand-cut backing showing through. Bent corners, cracked plates, rows out of line, an eyelet re-punched beside a torn one, a different cord spliced in.

This is a **finishing instruction, not a licence to make fewer plates.** Lace the panel complete, then remove — or leave specific positions empty by design. The gaps fall along the edges, at the waist and over the hip, the places that catch and flex.

Scattered absence reads as wear. Regular absence reads as a pattern. The labour is unchanged, and the backing behind the gaps now has to be worth looking at.

The build

1. Hex plates — the raw scale

Printed ×~440. See the plate section above. This is the long pole.

2. Flank panels — a laced pair, centre front over the ribs

Made ×2, ~110 plates each. Pattern these first.

Unmatched to each other. Laced and riveted onto flexible hand-cut leather-and-fabric backing — irregular, never a neat manufactured panel. The lacing is fine and mostly hidden behind the plates; the flex comes from the gaps and the lacing.

3. Scale cap — her LEFT shoulder

Made ×1, ~90 plates. A palm's width — the point of the shoulder only. Loose and scavenged. Three to five plates absent.

4. Scale patch — her LEFT outer thigh

Made ×1, ~130 plates. Dark bronze — the one warm thing in the entire costume, and the only place that colour appears.

5. Gauntlet — her RIGHT forearm

Printed ×1. A solid shell, dull grey steel, with a cluster of dim amber telltales at the wrist.

It must NOT match the other four pieces.

Printing it is worth **~150 hand-laced plates**, each of which would have needed two punched holes. It is the largest single saving in this build and it survives every revision, because it is a property of the piece rather than of the coverage.

6. Vest — fitted, sleeveless, dusty grey

Bought ×1. Heavy close-woven CLOTH, not hide — changed 2026-08-02, which turned this from a hide to find into a garment to source and distress.

The serpentine grain is a WEAVE, not a pressing. It has to be found in the cloth at purchase or it does not exist — there is no equivalent of embossing a hide. Look for a fine, close, irregular texture woven in, tonal and readable only in raking light. **Not a reptile print**, which is what the market will offer you.

7. Belts — waist, and a second slung diagonally below

Bought ×2. Worn taupe leather. See the dyeing note under boots.

8. Harness buckles and fittings

Bought ×6 — real hardware, not printed.

Printed buckles fail at the layer lines, under exactly the loads a costume puts on them.

Real load-rated buckles also read *more* correctly, not less: the Design Bible calls for industrial salvage over fine modern hardware. Printing is for buckles that are seen but not loaded.

9. Holster and knife sheath — her RIGHT thigh

Made ×2. Taupe leather, on the drawing side. Built around the WESTAR-35, not around a generic pistol.

10. WESTAR-35 blaster pistol

Printed ×1. On her **right** side, hip or thigh. Well used, never factory fresh.

11. Combat knife

Printed ×1. On her **left** hip. Well used.

12. Boots — mid-calf, grey-brown taupe

Bought ×1. Long leather straps wound criss-cross up the shaft.

Taupe is a dyeing and distressing job. Belts, holster, thigh strap, boots and the gauntlet cuff all read warm brown as bought. The costume drifts back toward brown on almost every image, and it will do the same on the bench.

13. Scale make-up

Made ×1. Fine scales on the exposed skin of her face, neck, collarbone, shoulders, arms and hands. A separate discipline from the armour.

The reptilian pupil is a CONTACT LENS on a human performer — the eye keeps its human shape, its lids, its lashes and its expression, and only the pupil is wrong. It is the single highest-value element in her make-up. Locked against `scale_portrait.png`, not against the costume reference.

Palette

Muted forest throughout — **dusty stone grey, grey-green, khaki and taupe**. Matte and low-noise, with nothing that would snag or rattle. All leather in grey-brown taupe.

The dark bronze thigh patch is the one warm thing in the costume.

Metallic but never bright: dulled, scratched, weathered to a low sheen, catching light in small dull glints across many facets.

What it is not

Do **not** make the armour leather. Do **not** make it a printed pattern. Do **not** make it forged or ceremonial armour.

The costume is **close-fitting and follows her figure** — waist defined, cut to the body. She is compact, agile and quick and the clothes must say so: nothing bulky, nothing loose, no oversized jacket swallowing her silhouette. Exposed skin at the shoulders and upper arms is functional, and it is what makes her inherited scales legible.

It is a working costume built for infiltration, not display. **Everything on it does a job.** Nothing polished, ornamental or factory fresh.

Revision History

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2026-08-04	Created, derived from the components : list added to <code>outfits.yaml</code> the same day. Assembled from decisions already recorded in <code>Costume-Build-Method.md</code> and <code>Character-Lock.md</code> — no new design